

PANIC IN THE BAKERY

The baker is used to the heat. He's been at work since the early hours and is carrying on as normal. Around him, though, people are worried. Why is the earth shaking? And what is that plume of ash doing above the mountain? Perhaps it is time to flee the city just in case there is any danger.



Ancient bread
This loaf was found in a baker's oven in Herculaneum, a town near Pompeii. The heat of the eruption turned it to carbon, preserving it. The stamp on the left is the guarantee of the bread's quality.

The bakery is built from cut stone, with mortar holding the blocks together.

The walls in Roman buildings were covered in a thin layer of plaster, giving them a smooth finish.

A friend has come to warn the baker and his wife about the seriousness of the situation—that dark ash cloud outside is growing fast.

The baker's apprentice flees, taking the mill's donkey with him.

The baker's wife picks up the family's money as she prepares to leave the city.

Lost money

Roman coins were made from gold, silver, or bronze and stamped with the image of the emperor of the time. These bronze coins show Emperor Vespasian.



The bakery floor needs constant mopping to keep it clear of flour.

Stone floors were durable and easy to clean.

Donkeys are expensive—the baker must have been doing well for himself.

These coins are from a hoard of 1,385 that were found hidden in a large clay jar.

"People bewailed their own fate or that of their relatives, and there were some who prayed for death in their terror of dying."

—Pliny the Younger, Roman author (62-113 CE)